BUFFERING CLAIMS

One by one, disengagement at major points of friction between the Indian Army and China's PLA in Ladakh is reducing tension. But there is concern that the creation of new demilitarised buffer zones along the LAC amount to a further loss of territory on the border with China

By Pradip R. Sagar





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There are no better places than international conferences to thrash out national differences, even the most intractable ones. At the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Samarkand in Uzbekistan on September 15-16, anticipation grew about the possibility of a meeting between Chinese president Xi Jinping and Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the sidelines. The two were sharing a stage for the first time since the protracted border stand-off on the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Ladakh that began in 2020 grievously damaged bilateral ties. The speculation was not without reason: after a breakthrough in corps commander-level talks (the 16th round) on September 8, troops of the Indian Army and the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China began disengaging from Patrolling Point (PP) 15 in the fiercely